

ANI

The original plan to set up the refinery at Nanar would have needed land from 17 villages in Ratnagiri and Sindhudurg. In his letter to Modi, Thackeray proposed an alternative site at Barsu as "90 per cent of the land available there is barren and no displacement of people is required". Assuring his complete support, the Maharashtra CM offered 13,000 hectares at Barsu for the refinery and 867.6 hectares in another village, Nate, for a crude oil terminal. "We are ready to hand over the land immediately after getting clearances from the Centre," he reportedly wrote to Modi.

Thackeray's assurance comes just a few years after he had cited environmental concerns to stall land acquisition by the MIDC in 2018. At that time, he had advised then CM Devendra Fadnavis to relocate the refinery to his hometown Nagpur—a suggestion that many laughed at as refineries are usually set up at places close to the sea, unlike Nagpur. And in the run-up to the 2019 Lok Sabha election, Thackeray agreed to a pre-poll alliance with BJP only after the proposed project was put on hold.

So, why this change of heart? According to a senior Shiv Sena leader, the CM has chosen business over environment. "An investment of Rs 3 lakh crore and employment to one lakh people is something he (Thackeray) can't overlook at a time of economic distress," the leader says. Partial lockdowns due to the Covid pandemic have cost Maharashtra 30 per cent of its revenue—around Rs 1.25 lakh crore in the past one year. Surely, Thackeray wants to avoid the 'anti-development' tag.

The Sena chief is also seeking some political dividend. His party is facing stiff competition from Sharad Pawar's NCP (Nationalist Congress Party) and the BJP in its bastion, Konkan, which elects 35 legislators to the 288-member assembly. The BJP has roped in Thackeray's bête noire Narayan Rane to shake the Sena. Rane, the Union minister for MSME, has an ambitious plan to provide loans at minimal rates to Konkan youth under certain schemes of his ministry. The NCP, too, is trying to spread its wings in the region, and in the face of its aggressive posturing, the Sena looks like a divided house. In January, senior Sena leader Ramdas Kadam held his colleague Anil Parab responsible for depression among party workers in Konkan. The infighting could damage the party's prospects in the next election.

Meanwhile, it has been alleged that the Sena's changed stance on the refinery has much to do with an intention to benefit some people who have bought land near Barsu. Nitesh Rane, the BJP MLA from Kankavali, alleges that Sena leaders are involved in the land dealings. Uday Samant, higher and technical education minister, refutes the allegation. "If you check the land records, you will know the real landowners in the area," he says. Samant had defected from the NCP to the Sena in 2019.

While the CM is yet to comment on the issue, his son and environment minister Aaditya Thackeray said on March 28 that the refinery will come up only after seeking the consent of locals. "There are two opinions (for and against) about the refinery. It is most important that the project is discussed and local people are taken into confidence," he told reporters. "Second is what the project-affected people will get, and their relocation. The third thing is ensuring that local people, including women, get jobs."

Thackeray's about-turn has stunned Sena workers in Konkan. It will be interesting to see how he defends his revised stand. ■